Risk Assessment Climbing and Abseiling

Location: Fox Coverts Campsite

Assessed on: 18 August 2012 **Checked by:**

Assessed by: Phill Sparks (HDSC Climbing Manager)

Hazard	Who is at risk?	Existing Control Measures	Risk	Comments
Instructor competence	Tower user	A Scout, Girlguiding or MTUK climbing instructor must be present whenever the tower is in use. Activity must run to POR and SPA. Instructors work to their authorisation and competence.	Low	Proof of qualification must be shown to the Climbing Manager before the session. The Climbing Manager should give a tower induction to all external instructors.
Tower suitability	Tower user	Instructor to check tower and surrounds prior to session. Tower checked as part of campsite maintenance checks. Inform participants that holds may spin.	Low	inc. annual check by scaffolder
Equipment worthiness	Tower user	All equipment checked before and after each session. Equipment replaced at end of life or shows signs of damage. All equipment use is logged on the appropriate sheet. No personal equipment used on participants.	Low	
Equipment failure	Tower user	Where appropriate, all setup has redundancy. Check setup every few sessions.	Low	i.e. 2 slings and karabiners on a top-roped climb.
Falling equipment	All	Everyone within fenced area must wear a helmet. Include in safety talk information about risks and calls ("Below") Where possible, all equipment secured when above ground.	Low	i.e. not left lying loose on tower deck
Injury	Tower user	No loose clothing, hair, shoes or jewellery – include in safety talk. Wear personal protective equipment (PPE).	Low	No crocs, sandals or wellies. Tie back hair.
… requiring first aid	Tower user	First aider and first aid kit must be present whenever the tower is in use. Incidents recorded in incident book.	Medium	Minimum of first response.
Horseplay / Trips / Slips	All	Include in safety talk information about trip hazards. Stop activity if participants are uncontrollable.	Low	e.g. Shoe laces, ropes, patio Leaders to assist instructors
Adverse weather: wet / cold / hot	All	Weather and participants monitored. Activity stopped if necessary.	Low	
Lightening strike	All	Activity stopped until 30 minutes after last thunder / lightening.	Medium	

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Fall	Tower user	Safety rope used on **all** abseilers and climbers.	Low	
… due to person not being connected to safety system	Tower user	All persons above the ground must be secured in a way so they cannot fall. When transferring between systems they must be connected to the new system first.	Low	Tied directly to the tower, on safety rope or ascenders (on ladders only)
… due to incorrectly fitted harness	Tower user	Harnesses and helmets checked by instructor before individual begins abseiling or climbing.	Low	
… due to poor belaying	Tower user	Ensure belayers manage only one rope and receive adequate instruction / supervision.	Medium	Consider backing up the dead rope
… due to distractions	Tower user	All phones switched off / put away when sessions in progress.	Low	
… due to slip on ladders	Ladder user	Anyone on the ladders should wear shoes with heels.	Low	
Problem during abseiling (e.g. trapped clothing)	Tower user	Rope system must be setup to allow instructor to deal with any problem, i.e. to be able to lower a person to the ground. No loose clothing, hair, jewellery, etc.	Low	Use locked off Italian hitch or descenders to secure abseil ropes. Bring hair bands
Cragfast participant	Tower user	Participants climb only 2m until instructor is confident that they are comfortable climbing and lowering. Instructors offer appropriate support to enable participant to regain control and retain dignity for him or herself. Instructors ensure that a rescue is possible at all times.	Low	
Unauthorised use	All	Activity locked when not in use, warning signs displayed. Holds removed during closed season (Nov – Mar).	Medium	Despite signs, there's nothing to stop people from trying to use the tower.
Covid-19	All	In addition to the campsite Covid rules, the climbing team will:	Low	
… close contact	All	Encourage instructors to wear a mask when in prolonged close contact, for example, when fitting helmets & harnesses. Limit close contact by having only 1 person directly in front of any instructor at a time, especially when fitting helmets & harnesses.	Low	This is not necessary when stepping in for a short task, like tying on a climber.

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… cross contamination	All	Climbers should clean their hands before entering the climbing area, between each climb, and when leaving the climbing area. Instructors should clean hands before, throughout and after each session.	Low	
		Quarantine equipment between sessions for a minimum of overnight. Hardware (metals and helmets) may be wiped down with an antiviral spray or wipe in lieu of quarantine. Manufacturers often recommend 72 hours, however the life of Covid-19 is reduced when operating outdoors.		Software (harnesses, ropes, and slings) cannot be effectively washed or wiped down as they then need to completely dry out naturally.
		Keep sharing of equipment to a minimum. It may be acceptable for a unit or group to share equipment between members, reducing or eliminating the need to quarantine between some sessions.		

Reviewed on	Reviewed by	Comments
5/May/2013	Phill Sparks	Anyone on the ladders should wear shoes with heels. No distractions!
28/Feb/2014	Phill Sparks	No use of personal equipment with participants.
27/Jan/2015	Phill Sparks	Added: tower induction; no crocs, sandals, or wellies; lightning strike. Updated: instructor competence.
21/Jul/2021	Phill Sparks	Added: Covid-19 control measures
8/Feb/2023	Phill Sparks	Additional Helmet risk assessment written, used in combination with this risk assessment.